Perfect

By Mary Gallagher

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: Women's liberation, politics, social issues . . . .
ACTRESS 2: Dating is much more difficult today than it was before women became so liberated.
ACTRESS 1: Today we're looking for more than a provider: We want intelligence, social awareness, sensitivity, strength . . . . Let's face it . . We want it all.
ACTRESS 2: Don't forget sexy . . he has to be sexy.
ACTRESS 1: In "Perfect" by Mary Gallagher, Tina and her husband "Binky" have invited Kitty and her potential boyfriend over for dinner.
SIMULTANEOUSLY: Dan is . . . . . PERFECT by Mary Gallagher
He is certainly not . . . . PERFECT by Mary Gallagher

TINA: So wadaya think?

KITTY: So far, he's fine

TINA: I think he is perfect!

KITTY: He's great-looking, that's for sure

TINA: My God, Kitty, *I'm* drooling! And *smart*, he's like Joe Genius at the law firm, Binky says

KITTY: He seems like he's bright, he's read a book lately, at least

TINA: He reads like a maniac. Like at the office, Binky says everybody's talking about who would want to try out for "Survivor: The Galapagos," and Dan is like, "You know I was reading this *book* last night," and everyone goes, "Oh." But I mean, you *love* that.

KITTY: But he's funny too. I mean I think he's said a lot of funny things tonight

TINA: Are you kidding? God, he is *hysterical!* He gets Binks laughing on the phone, like Binks can't stop, like with *tears*

KITTY: And he offered to help clear the table.

TINA: *That,* I could not believe.

KITTY: Of course, he *is* a guest

TINA: But *still.* They *won't,* you know?

KITTY: It's like the last bastion, the Alamo

TINA: Or even if they did it for some brief exciting era, now it's over. You get up, you pick up a plate, and they dig in, they get this look, this *rigid* look..

KITTY: Sort of daunted, but entrenched...

TINA: And they start talking sports.

KITTY: Or corporate talk. "To the best of my knowledge, Fred."

TINA: Right! Right! That's the best thing about Binky being Binky. When people start that crap with him, it just doesn't cut it. "To the best of my knowledge, Binky..." *[They start giggling. They lean on each other,* How about that Dan guy you've been dating? *[About the vibes.]* WOO!

KITTY: Yeah. It's great. So far.

TINA: What is this "so far"? There is no hidden horror. Trust me. I told you, I looked into him. Not only is he not attached, he has the perfect history. He was married once, so he's not afraid of commitment. But they were really young and it just didn't work out. But they're still friends, he even plays squash with her new husband, so clearly he's not bitter. *But,* they've been divorced for *years,* and he's dated a lot and lived with two other women, so he's not hung up on her. No kids, so there is no issue of

"maybe his kids will hate you." But he has one nephew and two nieces and he adores them, so he's not *opposed* to kids. *Plus* he doesn't smoke. I mean, if you don't take him, take Binky and *I'll* takehim!

KITTY: I really am attracted to him

TINA: Tell me about it! It's like...a force!

KITTY: Yeah?

TINA: Yeah! Also you keep grinning.

KITTY: I do? Oh God

TINA: You both do. Me and Binky feel left out.

KITTY: God, how embarrassing

TINA: So what's the hold-up?

KITTY: *[Beat, then.]* You're gonna get pissed off.

TINA: I might, I'll tell ya. I oughta get annointed Queen for coming up with him. Or Pope. 'Cause do you know what's *out there?*

KITTY: I know, I know, believe me.. .Okay. Look at the evidence. He's a corporate lawyer. He makes a lot of money.

TINA: It's not that great, he makes like what Binky makes

KITTY: Compared to say the average income of the average working

TINA: Okay, okay, right

KITTY: He drives a BMW He went to Fiji on vacation. He makes jokes about his investment portfolio, but he *has* a portfolio and he's only, what? Thirty-six?

TINA: Thirty-eight. That's better, men are creeps till they're thirty eight. See,

he's even thirty-eight! *What are you afraid of?*

KITTY: Who do you think he voted for?

TINA: *[Stopped; then stalls for time.]* Huh?

KITTY: I knew it!

TINA: No no, wait, hold on

KITTY: God, it's all so *depressing*

TINA: No, wait a minute, we don't know

KITTY: You know, you know in your heart

TINA: I don't! You *never* know. Binky's just the same as Dan, he's practically a clone of Dan, and Binky didn't vote for him

KITTY: That's because you told him if he voted for him, he would not get any for four more years.

TINA: But he wouldn't've done it anyway, Binky never *really* votes for them. Sometimes, yeah, he talks the talk, just to get me all wound up, but "once inside the booth," you know

KITTY: This is denial, Tina.

TINA: No! Even when Reagan died, the Great Communicator and the state funeral and all, and everyone kept saying, "Ronald Reagan made us feel good about ourselves again," and then they'd play these sound bites from his speeches? And Binky said, "Tina, listen to his voice, he sounds like a child molester." *[Doing creepy Reagan.]* "Come with me, little girl, it's morning in America..."

KITTY: Yeah, yeah...we can all sneer and laugh at them, but do you think they

care? They sell yo-yos in the gift shop of the Ronald Reagan Presidential Library, *yo-yos* with Ronald Reagan's name on them, that's how much they care.

TINA: All I'm saying is, Binky doesn't vote for them

KITTY: It's how Dan votes that worries me!

KITTY: *[Bleakly.]* Because if he votes for them, I'll cry, or puke, or something.. .

TINA: *[Beat; then, gentry.]* Look. Why don't you wait. You know? Enjoy it for a while. You guys could have so much fun. And he could be the greatest guy in America. Don't ruin it before you even

KITTY: No, I can't face falling for him, getting suckered in, but all the time suspecting, probing, and then finding out! No. I'd rather end it now. One clean... *[Chopping motion.]* I'll go back in, I'll ask him. [KITTY *turns to exit.* TINA *grabs her.]*

TINA: Now, dammit, Kitty! This is really self-destructive. I don't think you *want* to have a good relationship. Or even a good time! I . think...I think, and I am serious, you are *avoiding* real live men

KITTY: No! There are certain things-principles, gut instincts, call them what you will-that every person has to cling to. That's what makes us who we are. I would not ask *you* to give up the deepest convictions that you have

TINA: *[Annoyed.]* Name one!

KITTY: -and you would not want me to throw away my most dearly-held beliefs

TINA: I want you to have a nice man in your life! I want you to be happy!

KITTY: ...Yeah, I know. And I want that too, I do! But I can't stand the way this country's going. And if I can't stop it, at least I won't participate. I won't have a relationship with anyone who votes for them.

TINA: *[Beat, then, flatly.]* You're talking about every man who makes a decent living

KITTY: No!

TINA: Well, the vast majority

KITTY: No! No! In 2000, Bush didn't even win! He sneaked in the back door because his brother's flunkies blinded senior citizens and wouldn't let black people vote!

TINA: Oh God, here we go...

KITTY: And how about all those people who stopped voting *years* ago, because they were too weak and wasted, *drained,* from all those years of *rage* to drag their bodies to the polls! Worn out by years of Reagan and Old Bad Bush and Ollie North and Newt Gingrich and Trent Lott and *Antonin Scalia, God!* And it just gets more horrendous, now it's George the Worst! And Cheney, Rumsfeld, Rove, Rice

TINA: Whoa, whoa, didn't you just skip eight years? Clinton was one of ours.

KITTY: Clinton broke our hearts, but having "sex" at the office is not the same as throwing out social security so that we can spend our golden years living in cardboard cartons! Clinton didn't try to give away the arctic wilderness! He didn't call an education bill "No Child Left Behind" and then leave behind the funding! He didn't bring back Star Wars and gag

orders for birth control and trillion dollar deficits! He didn't lock up immigrants for years just "on suspicion," without lawyers or human rights! He didn't attack a *country* just so he could carve it up and hand the pieces to his friends and act like no one's dying! And Clinton could speak in *sentences*, with *clauses*. He could sustain a complex thought! Bush is a vacuum, a black hole, I'm surprised the Lincoln bed doesn't get sucked into him. I repeat: I won't have a relationship with anyone who votes for them.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Mary Gallagher
Book: Found in 25 Ten-Minute Plays from Actor's Theatre of Louisville
ISBN: 0573625581
Publisher: Samuel French, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): June 1989